

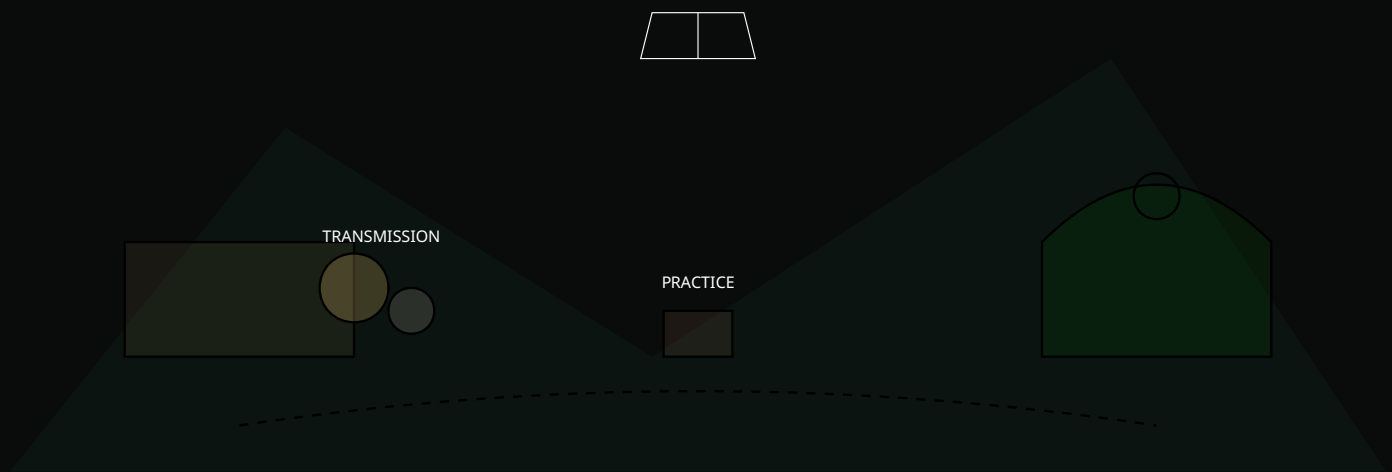
EDUCATION IN TRADITIONAL SOCIETY

“Before the classroom, there was the community.”

Before education was measured by classrooms, examinations and certificates, people learned in many other ways. A child learned language at home. A young person watched an elder work. A student memorized verses. A farmer learned by observing seasons and land. An apprentice learned by doing. A child heard stories before learning to write them. Religious knowledge could be taught through the mosque, madrasa, family and teacher. Social knowledge was learned through participation. In traditional Orakzai society, as in many communities, education was therefore not necessarily a separate institution. It could be woven into everyday life. Learning happened through listening, watching, repetition, practice, memory and responsibility. But traditional education was not one single system. It differed by family, village, religious institution, occupation, gender, period and access to teachers. Understanding this distinction is essential. The history of education is not simply the history of schools. It is also the history of how knowledge moved from one generation to another.

EDUCATION IN TRADITIONAL SOCIETY

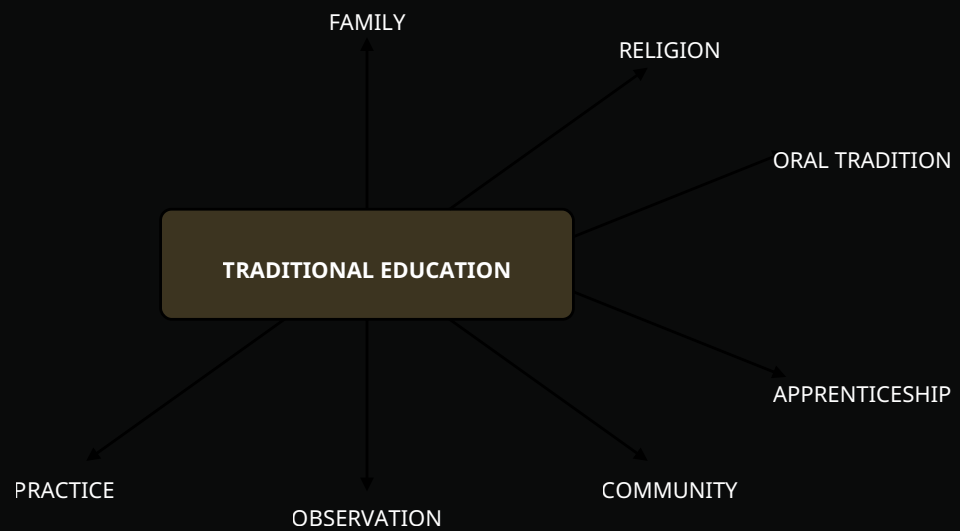
"Before the classroom, there was the community."



"A spatial and social model of traditional knowledge transmission in Orakzai."

DEFINING TRADITIONAL EDUCATION

Traditional education does not necessarily mean "education without knowledge." Instead, it refers to the diverse systems of knowledge transmitted outside of modern standardized school systems. These systems include formal elements, such as religious instruction in madrasas, and informal elements, such as apprenticeship in agriculture or crafts. It is a holistic framework where family, religion, oral tradition, and community participation intersect to form a complete knowledge system.



“The components of the traditional educational framework.”

ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC

PASHTUN-WIDE

REGIONAL

ISLAMIC

FAMILY-SPECIFIC

ORAL HISTORY

HISTORICAL

INSTITUTIONAL

THE FIRST CLASSROOM: THE FAMILY

The home (*Kor*) serves as the primary environment for early childhood education. Within the family, a child learns the foundations of identity: language, manners (*Adab*), basic religious rituals, and social responsibilities. This learning happens not through formal lessons, but through a continuous cycle of observation, imitation, and practice. A child watches their parents and siblings, copies their actions, and gradually masters the skills necessary for family and community life.

CHILD — FAMILY — OBSERVATION — PRACTICE — KNOWLEDGE

“The pedagogical cycle of family-based learning.”

THE HUJRA: A SOCIAL ACADEMY

The Hujra is documented as a vital "Learning Hub" for Pashtun youth. It serves as a social academy where young men learn the complexities of tribal history, conflict resolution, and community leadership. By listening to the conversations of elders and observing the conduct of guests, youth acquire the "soft skills" of Pashtunwali—hospitality, negotiation, and social ethics. It is a space where oral history is not just remembered, but practiced and transmitted to the next generation.²



“The Hujra as a multi-dimensional educational institution.”

ECOLOGICAL KNOWLEDGE AND OBSERVATION

Traditional education in Orakzai is deeply connected to the land. Orakzai tribes possess sophisticated Traditional Ecological Knowledge (TEK), particularly regarding wild food and medicinal plants. Research by Ahmad et al. (2026) documents how this knowledge is passed down through direct observation and seasonal practice. A young person learns to identify, harvest, and conserve plant species by working alongside elders in the subtropical and temperate forests of the district.¹

LAND

OBSERVATION

USAGE

CONSERVATION

TRADITIONAL ECOLOGICAL KNOWLEDGE (TEK)

“The transmission pathway of land-based ecological wisdom in Orakzai.”

MOSQUE AND MADRASA: THE RELIGIOUS HUB

Religious education has historically provided the primary framework for formal literacy and moral guidance. Mosques serve as local centers for learning basic Islamic principles, while madrasas offer more advanced instruction. In Orakzai, institutions like *Madrassa Anwar-ul-Islam* have historically been centers for religious scholarship. This system emphasizes memorization (*Hifz*), recitation, and the study of ethics, providing a shared moral language for the community.⁴

Mosque Learning

Foundational religious literacy, prayer, and community ethics taught at the village level.

Madrasa Education

Advanced study of theology, law, and manuscripts in specialized institutions.



“The institutional framework of religious and moral education.”

ORAL TRADITION AND MEMORY

Oral tradition is the quietest way a people remembers itself. Through storytelling, poetry, and proverbs (*Mataloona*), social wisdom is condensed and transmitted. Memory is not just a passive storage of facts, but an active educational tool. A young person listens, memorizes, repeats, and eventually understands the deeper meanings of the narratives they inherit. This oral archive ensures that tribal history and Pashtun ethics survive across generations without the need for written certificates.

LISTEN

MEMORIZE

REPEAT

TRANSMIT

ORAL KNOWLEDGE SYSTEM

“The cognitive and social workflow of oral education.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

We often think of education as something that begins when we enter a school and ends when we graduate. But in the Orakzai valley, education has always been a lifelong journey. It is the story our grandfather tells us in the Hujra; it is the way our mother teaches us the language of our land; it is the silence of the mosque where we learn our faith. Traditional education was never just about facts—it was about becoming a responsible member of the community. Today, as we build modern schools and universities, we must not forget these older ways of learning. The future of Orakzai education lies in the balance: honoring the wisdom of our elders while embracing the tools of the modern world. We are not just students of books; we are students of our heritage.

